

like Pangong Tso. In June occurred the violent clash in the Galwan Valley, in which 20 Indian soldiers and an 'undisclosed' number of Chinese troops lost their lives. However, it has been alleged by some locals in Ladakh that Indian authorities had ignored steady intrusions by the Chinese despite being repeatedly warned. As the People's Liberation Army (PLA) of China brought in troops, armour and heavy equipment up to the LAC, Indian military carried out a 'mirror deployment'—at its height, Indian troop deployment swelled to 50,000, as heavy transport aircraft airdropped equipment and provisions. Since then, multiple rounds of military and diplomatic negotiations have gradually defused tension and led to disengagement and drawback of men and materiel at five out of seven friction points along the LAC in eastern Ladakh. Even during the crisis, the military was helping with logistics to combat the Covid pandemic—from setting up hospitals to flying in oxygen.

In June 2022, the government brought in the radical Agnipath recruitment scheme to build youthful, tech-savvy and future-ready armed forces. Under it, youth would be trained as soldiers, airmen and sailors for four years. It was opposed by those who felt it would lower the efficiency of the military, as well as by many youth, who thought they would be left in the lurch after four years, as the scheme allows for permanent recruitment of only 25 per cent of 'agniveers'. However, the Centre has promised that Agniveers would be given priority for recruitment in central police forces and Assam Rifles.

Though India is amongst the largest importers of arms, the government is pushing hard to bring 'self-reliance' in defence under the Make in India initiative. To boost domestic manufacturing, the MoD embargoed the import of 4,666 military items and weapons systems in 2020. That year, the government allowed FDI under the automatic route (depending on a case to case basis) to go up to 74 per cent (from 49 per cent), and up to 100 per cent through the government route, wherever it would result in access to modern technology. In the past four years, India's defence manufacturing industry has achieved several milestones. One was the commissioning of the Indigenous Aircraft Carrier INS *Vikrant*—the largest naval ship to be designed and built in India—in September 2022. The other was the Light Combat Helicopter (LCH) Prachand.

Defence exports reached a high of around Rs 16,000 crore in 2022-23. India is exporting military hardware to 85 countries. While India is exporting Dornier-228 planes, 155 mm Advanced Towed Artillery Guns (ATAGs), BrahMos missiles, Akash missile systems and Pinaka rockets, some countries have expressed interest in the LCA (Light Combat Aircraft) Tejas and Prachand. ■

BOLD & BRAVE

India gets its first CDS in Gen. Bipin Rawat. His untimely death sees Gen. Anil Chauhan take over

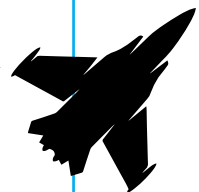
74%
FDI allowed in defence sector through automatic route: 100% via govt route

Agnipath scheme to recruit soldiers for 4 years



BUT...

Theatrisation of armed forces work in progress



31 **Fighter jet squadrons with IAF, as against authorisation for 42**